

THE CHARACTER CARD

A player character is recorded on a character sheet, which is divided into cards.

In addition to a character's four **theme cards** and the **crew theme card** (explained above), each PC also has a **loadout theme card** to record their gear (see **Loadout**, page 114) and a **character card** with:

- Their **Essence**, their unique combination of theme types
- Crew relationship tags
- Evolution points (starting with none)
- Moments of Evolution (starting with none)
- Specials, a section for recording special abilities including the Essence Special (page 134)

TAGS

WORDS OVER NUMBERS

The core building blocks of *:Otherscape* are **tags**, which are short descriptors. Tags describe almost everything in the game: your character's abilities, resources, conditions, relationships, etc. If it's important, it has a tag.

TYPES OF TAGS

- **Power tags:** Permanent tags that describe an essential part of your character that is usually **useful**, like being *charming* or always carrying a *gun*.
 - » **Loadout tags** are a type of power tags that describe additional resources like equipment or contacts to which your character has access, but which need to be selected and loaded up before a job in order to be useful. See **Loadout** (page 114).
- **Weakness tags:** Permanent tags that describe an essential part of your character that is usually **troublesome**, like being *foolhardy* or a weapon that *often jams*. They help your character improve.
- **Story tags:** Situational tags that describe something in a scene like the weather (*raining*), the environment (*slippery*), a summoned creature (*specter*), or an improvised weapon (*bar stool*). They can be useful or troublesome based on the situation. See **Using Story Tags** (page 110).
- **Statuses:** Special tags that describe transient conditions, either useful or troublesome. They have a **tier** from 1 to 6 which defines their intensity (*wounded-3*). See **Using Statuses** (page 103).

Tags are highlighted in *yellow*, statuses in *green*.

TAG EXAMPLES

QUALITY

strong
wise
charming
trustworthy
rugged
aggressive
mysterious
positive outlook
can't con a con

GEAR

assault rifle
plastic handgun
grappling hook
tactical HUD overlay
binoculars
potion of mana homing missile
invisibility cloak
backpack

ASSETS

skyscraper
cushy bank account
hacking console
keys to corporate armory
boosted gyrocycle
anthroform drone
library of magic tomes
espionage satellite
a secret garden

ABILITY

shoot laser beams
aura of protection
jacked-up reflexes
built-in scanner
healing touch
illusory appearance
cast magic spells
long-range transmission
become incorporeal
see in the dark
feral instincts

SKILL

marksmanship
forensics
hacker
outdoorsy
nightlife influencer
leadership
all eyes on me
sneaky one
weaponsmith

CONNECTIONS

known in town
Eddie the informant
regular at the Xanadu
my sassy girlfriend
loyal to the company
rally the troops
my zombie servants
mom always said...
my gang

SCENE

severe acid rain
too dark to see
vantage point
ruins provide cover
magnetic field
razor-sharp turns
sticky webs
debris everywhere
distrust to strangers

STATUSES

bruised-2
firewalled-2
blinded-3
confident-3
choking-1
restrained-4
shielded-2
sick-5
supercharged-4

TAGS DRIVE THE STORY

Your action's chance of success is determined by dice rolls, and tags influence dice rolls for better or for worse. With the exception of statuses, all tags have the same value, the same effect on the dice roll: they give or subtract one point of Power to an action. Therefore, being able to shoot *destructive laser beams* or being skilled at *necromancy* has the same chance of influencing the narrative as being *alert* or a *smooth talker*.

What truly matters is **context**, how and when a tag is applicable: firing laser beams gives you a very different story compared to talking your way out of trouble. Therefore, **what you choose as your tags determines what will have an impact in your character's story.**

MORE DETAILS EQUALS MORE POWER

Because all tags have the same power to change the fiction, having a *knife* or having a *rocket launcher* has the same power when used to influence outcomes in the story. One is not inherently more powerful than the other; they simply can be used in different ways and situations. To have greater power over the outcome, describe your action with **more tags**: a *rocket launcher* with *anti-tank ammo*, *incinerating payload*, *weak point detection*, and *homing missiles* would be absolutely devastating.

NOT EVERYTHING NEEDS A TAG

Details in your story do not need to become tags in order to be true. A character can be handsome or rich without having a tag for it and a room could have suspicious crates in it or low light without such tags. However, details that don't have tags will matter less during the game and will have less of an effect on the story you tell, because they can't influence dice rolls. Use tags to highlight the details that have importance and impact in your character and in your game. The MC can interject to add a story tag to an important detail whenever it seems right (page 83).

TAG DURATION

Power tags and weakness tags are permanent features of your character. Story tags and statuses expire when it makes sense in the narrative. E.g., a *prone-3* status expires when the prone character has a chance to get up, or an *access codes* tag expires once the codes have been changed. In some cases, they can also become permanent.

BURNING TAGS

Sometimes the rules of the game call for tags to be **burned**, whether as a cost for a benefit or as a consequence.

- A burned power tag cannot be used until it is recovered.
- A burned story tag is removed.

When one of your power tags is burned, you can check the flame icon [🔥] next to it to record this, and then uncheck it when you recover the tag.

Burned power tags can be recovered when the rules state so or when it makes sense in the narrative. For example, if you're arrested and your *mono-edge knife* is confiscated (burned), you can recover it by taking action to break into the police evidence storage and retrieve your knife, or during **downtime** (see page 124), presumably by acquiring a replacement.

Burned story tags are removed and cannot be recovered. They can, however, be recreated using the standard rules for creating story tags.

THEMES

A theme is a major aspect of your character such as their unique skill set, technology, Mythical power, background, life mission, or personality. This aspect is represented by a collection of tags and other game features.

A player character has four themes. The aspects of your character represented by a theme will have the most impact on the story, for better or worse. Your character may have other aspects, which are not represented by a theme; for example they might have close friends or a piece of backstory not represented by a theme. These are still a part of your character, but they don't have direct game effects and therefore will probably not receive as much attention in the series as your themed aspects.



Your themes can change. Your character can and will undergo transformations that have them replace existing themes with new ones, making them a dynamic and evolving being with changing abilities and power sets.

THEME TYPES

A theme's type defines its focal point. There are 14 theme types presented in the core version of *:Otherscape*, divided into three categories. Each category represents one of the three major forces in the *:Otherscape* universe: Self, Mythos, and Noise.

- The **SELF** theme types represent your personal identity and all that defines you as a unique being. They include **Affiliation, Assets, Expertise, Horizon, Personality, and Troubled Past.**
- The **MYTHOS** theme types represent a major Source your character is using, the powers it grants you, and your relationship to it. They include **Artifact, Companion, Esoterica, and Exposure.**
- The **NOISE** theme types represent your superhuman technological abilities. They include **Augmentation, Cutting Edge, Cyberspace, and Drones.**

The balance of Self, Mythos, and Noise determines your character's cosmological nature as a being, your **Essence** (page 134) and your access to a specific Essence Special.

MOTIVATIONS & THE DECAY TRACK

Each theme has a motivation that defines how it drives your character to act in the world. The type of motivation is based on the theme's category:

- Self themes have an **Identity** that you have to uphold in order to maintain your connection with that part of yourself.
- Mythos themes have a **Ritual** that you have to perform to maintain your connection with that Source.
- Noise themes have an **Itch**, an impulse you have to satisfy in order to maintain your integration with that technology.

Acting against your Identity, neglecting your Ritual, or resisting your Itch can eventually lead you to replace your theme. Every time you turn your back on your motivation, you mark one **Decay** box on that theme's Decay track. Once you mark all three Decay boxes on a theme, you replace it with a different theme (see **Replacing Themes**, page 138). This represents your character ignoring or inhibiting a part of themselves for so long that it moved to the backburner, transformed, withered, or was lost. Another aspect then takes center stage, represented by a new theme.